Plan 8 · Nepal Overland (international, fits the budget)

Weekly Hyderabad–Raxaul train on 24 Dec (Thursday) → Kathmandu's three Durbar Squares, Pashupatinath, Boudha → Bandipur hill town → Pokhara for the New Year street festival and Sarangkot sunrise → back via Patna. 6 people · no visa

At a glance

Route	Hyderabad → (17005, 42 h) → Raxaul → walk into **Birgunj** 1N → **Kathmandu** 2N → **Bandipur** 1N → **Pokhara** 2N (NYE) → Birgunj → Raxaul → Patna 1N → (12792) → Secunderabad 3 Jan night
Why Nepal	The only international trip that fits ₹25–30k for these dates. No visa, no flights (the weekly train leaves exactly on Thursday 24 Dec), and INR is widely accepted. Himalayan views (Annapurna, Machhapuchhre, Manaslu) and the Pokhara Street Festival (usually 28 Dec–1 Jan).
Snow	No snow in Kathmandu/Pokhara (2–20 °C). Big snow-peak views, not snow play. Pick Plans 1–7 if you want to walk in snow
Documents	**Passport or voter ID** for every adult (Aadhaar is generally not accepted at the border). Children: passport or school ID + birth certificate
Money	₹1 ≈ NPR 1.6. Indian ₹100 and smaller notes are accepted freely. A 2025–26 rule change allows ₹200/₹500 notes up to ₹25,000 per person (sources differ on details), so carry mostly ₹100s and use UPI where shops accept it
Budget per person (6 people)	**≈ ₹18.8k shoestring** (SL, buses) · **≈ ₹28.1k recommended** (3A, hired van for the first leg). Paragliding is extra (NPR 9,000–12,000 ≈ ₹5,600–7,500)

Why not Bhutan, Sri Lanka, Thailand, Malaysia or Vietnam?

Bhutan: SDF ₹1,200 per person per night + HYD–Bagdogra flights (₹13–17k return) + a Bhutanese car comes to ≈ ₹40–46k. Sri Lanka, Thailand, Malaysia, Vietnam: the December return flights alone are ₹21–35k. Details are in the Overview PDF.

Trains (both directions)

Leg	Train	Time	Runs	Fare (SL · 3A)	Notes
Out	**17005 Hyderabad-Raxaul Exp**	Hyderabad Deccan **23:10 Thu 24 Dec** (Secunderabad 23:30) → Raxaul ~16:50–17:00 Sat 26 Dec	Thu only	≈ ₹870 · ≈ ₹2,300	~42 h. No pantry car on some days, so carry food
Back	**12792 Danapur–Secunderabad SF Exp**	Danapur (Patna) **12:15 Sat 2 Jan** → Secunderabad ~21:30 Sun 3 Jan	Daily	≈ ₹840 · ≈ ₹2,200	~33 h. Home 3 Jan night
Not usable	17006 Raxaul–Hyderabad	Raxaul 03:15 Sun → Hyderabad 19:40 Mon	Sun only		3 Jan departure gets you home 4 Jan

Book 17005 today: it's weekly, so there's no second chance. Both trains are well inside the 60-day window. Fallback for the way back if 12792 is full: Patna → Hyderabad flight on 2 Jan (IndiGo direct, typically ₹5–8k), or Kathmandu → Delhi → Hyderabad flights (≈ ₹13–16k).

Inside Nepal

Leg	How	Time	Approx cost / person
Raxaul → Birgunj	Cycle/e-rickshaw across the open border (5 km); no immigration formalities for Indians, but carry ID	30 min	₹50–100
Birgunj → Kathmandu	Day bus (NPR ~500–900) or a hired Hiace/Scorpio for 6 (≈ NPR 15–18k)	6–8 h	₹400–560 bus · ≈ ₹1,700 van
Kathmandu → Dumre → Bandipur	Tourist bus to Pokhara from Sorhakhutte 07:00, get off at **Dumre**; jeep/taxi 8 km up (20–30 min)	4–5 h	NPR ~800–1,200 + jeep
Bandipur → Pokhara	Jeep to Dumre + local/tourist bus	2.5–3 h	NPR ~400
Pokhara → Birgunj	Direct day bus via Narayanghat	7–9 h	NPR 1,000–1,500
Raxaul → Patna	Bus via Motihari–Muzaffarpur	5–6 h	₹350–500

Day-by-day itinerary

Day 1 · Thu 24 Dec · Hyderabad → on the Raxaul train

• Day free in Hyderabad. **23:10 17005** from Hyderabad Deccan (23:30 Secunderabad).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** —

Day 2 · Fri 25 Dec · On the train

• A long run through central India into Bihar. Christmas on the rails: carry food for 6 (no pantry on some runs) and power banks.

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹500 food

Day 3 · Sat 26 Dec · Raxaul → Birgunj

• Raxaul ~17:00 → rickshaws across the border → **Birgunj** (Ghantaghar, Gahawa Mai temple). Early night.

Stay: Birgunj hotel (3 rooms) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹100 rickshaw + ₹600–900 stay + ₹500 food

Day 4 · Sun 27 Dec · Birgunj → Kathmandu · Boudhanath + Pashupatinath aarti

• 06:30 departure; ~6–8 h through the hills. Check in to the Airbnb near Thamel/Swayambhu.

• **Boudhanath stupa** at golden hour → **Pashupatinath evening aarti** on the Bagmati ghats (~18:00).

Stay: Airbnb Kathmandu | **Day spend (per person):** ₹500–1,700 transfer + ₹400 taxis + ₹700 food

Day 5 · Mon 28 Dec · Swayambhu · Kathmandu, Patan & Bhaktapur Durbar Squares

• Sunrise at **Swayambhunath** (Monkey Temple) → **Kathmandu Durbar Square** (Kumari Ghar) → **Patan Durbar Square** and Patan Museum → **Bhaktapur** for sunset, juju dhau (king curd) and Nyatapola temple. Dinner in Thamel.

• Show your Indian ID for SAARC-rate tickets (far cheaper than the foreigner rate).

Stay: Airbnb Kathmandu | **Day spend (per person):** ₹400 taxis + ₹700 entries + ₹800 food

Day 6 · Tue 29 Dec · Kathmandu → Bandipur (offbeat hill town)

• 07:00 tourist bus → Dumre → jeep up to **Bandipur**: car-free Newari bazaar on a ridge. **Tundikhel** and **Thani Mai** viewpoints for Manaslu and Annapurna at sunset. Optional on the way: Manakamana cable car at Kurintar.

Stay: Bandipur guesthouse / homestay | **Day spend (per person):** ₹600 transport + ₹700 food

Day 7 · Wed 30 Dec · Bandipur sunrise → Pokhara · Phewa + Peace Pagoda

• Sunrise at Thani Mai → bus to **Pokhara** (~2.5 h). **Phewa lake** boating to Tal Barahi temple → **World Peace Pagoda** for sunset over the Annapurnas.

Stay: Airbnb Pokhara (Lakeside) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹250 bus + ₹300 boat + ₹800 food

Day 8 · Thu 31 Dec · Sarangkot sunrise · caves & falls · NYE street festival

• 05:00 taxi to **Sarangkot** for sunrise on Machhapuchhre/Annapurna. Optional tandem paragliding from Sarangkot (NPR 9,000–12,000).

• **Davis Falls**, **Gupteshwor Mahadev cave**, International Mountain Museum.

• **Pokhara Street Festival** on Lakeside (usually 28 Dec–1 Jan): food stalls, music, the biggest NYE party in Nepal.

Stay: Airbnb Pokhara | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 taxi + ₹1,000 food/NYE

Day 9 · Fri 1 Jan · Pokhara → Birgunj → Raxaul → Patna

• 07:00 day bus to Birgunj (7–9 h) → rickshaw across the border → bus Raxaul → Patna (5–6 h). Long day, so pack snacks and keep phones charged.

Stay: Airbnb / hotel near Patna Jn or Danapur | **Day spend (per person):** ₹700–1,000 bus + ₹450–600 bus + ₹700–1,000 stay + ₹600 food

Day 10 · Sat 2 Jan · Patna → train home

- Optional morning at Gandhi Ghat / Patna Museum. **12:15 12792** from Danapur.

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹600 food

Day 11 · Sun 3 Jan · Home

- Secunderabad ~21:30.

Where you sleep: Airbnb picks for 6 (best-rated and budget)

Nights	Area	Best-rated pick	Budget pick	Est. Dec price, 6 people / night	≈ per person / night
2 (27–28 Dec)	Kathmandu	**Boutique 3BHK Tibet Designer Apartment** (Swayambhu, near Thamel): 5.0★ (~80) · **Spacious 3BR near Thamel** 4.9★ (30+), 6 guests	**The Magnolia 3BHK** (Paknajol) 4.88★ (16) · **White House Studio 3BHK** (Uttardhoka)	₹4,000–6,500	₹650–1,100
1 (29 Dec)	Bandipur	Not on Airbnb: old Newari guesthouses on the bazaar	Rooms NPR 2,000–3,500 (₹1,250–2,200) × 3	₹3,800–6,600	₹650–1,100
2 (30–31 Dec)	Pokhara (Lakeside)	**Full Lakeview 3BHK Penthouse**: 4.91★ (79), 6 guests · **Hilltop Villa w/ Private Pool** 3BR 4.96★ (~80), 15 min from Lakeside	Lakeside rooftop apartment, 1 min to the lake (4.62★, 84; 3rd floor, no lift)	₹6,000–10,000	₹1,000–1,650

Listing names, ratings and review counts come from Airbnb search results in Nov 2026. Airbnb blocks automated price checks, so the 'Dec price for 6' column is an **estimate** for an entire 3-bedroom place over the holiday week. Check the live total for your dates.

How to pick the best-rated vs the cheapest on Airbnb

Filters: Guests = 6 · Type of place = **Entire home** · Bedrooms ≥ 3 (or 2 + sofa-beds) · tick **Guest favourite** · toggle **'Display total before taxes'** so the price includes cleaning and service fees.

Best-rated vs cheapest: sort by price after setting the filters, then pick the cheapest listing with ≥ 4.7★ and ≥ 20 reviews. A 5.0★ with 3 reviews is not more reliable than a 4.8★ with 150.

Winter questions to message the host before booking: room heaters (some charge ₹300–500/night per heater), geyser/hot water, power backup, whether a car reaches the door (Old Manali, Vashisht, Jibhi and McLeodganj often have steep stairs), and snow-time access.

NYE rules: many hosts set a 2–3 night minimum for 30 Dec–1 Jan. Book those nights first with flexible or moderate cancellation.

Where Airbnb is thin (Zuluk, Aritar, Rinchenpong, Sari/Chopta, Sangla/Kalpa, Bandipur, Spiti), book homestays by phone or on Booking.com / MakeMyTrip. Usually 3 rooms × ₹1,500–3,000 with meals.

Places: main vs offbeat

Place	Type	Why
Pashupatinath, Boudhanath, Swayambhunath	Main (UNESCO)	Nepal's great temples and stupas
Kathmandu, Patan, Bhaktapur Durbar Squares	Main (UNESCO)	Newari palaces, woodcarving, juju dhau
Bandipur	Offbeat	Car-free ridge bazaar, Himalayan sunsets
Phewa lake, Peace Pagoda, Sarangkot	Main	Annapurna views
Davis Falls, Gupteshwor cave	Main	Short stops
Pokhara Street Festival	Seasonal	New Year on Lakeside

Bike / scooty rentals

Where	Rates	Notes
Pokhara Lakeside	Scooty NPR 1,200–1,800/day · 150 cc NPR 1,800–2,500	Indian DL accepted at most shops; fuel ≈ NPR 175/l. Good for Sarangkot by day
Kathmandu (Thamel)	Scooty NPR 1,200–1,500/day	Heavy traffic and dust; taxis are easier for 6

What to wear

Kathmandu and Pokhara are 2–20 °C in late December: a fleece + light padded jacket and a cap are enough. Sarangkot at 05:00 and Bandipur nights are cold (≈ 2–5 °C). No snow gear needed; skip the rentals.

Budget per person (6 people sharing)

Item (per person, 6 sharing)	Shoestring	Recommended	Notes
17005 Hyderabad → Raxaul (Thu 23:10)	₹870	₹2,300	SL vs 3A
Raxaul → Birgunj border rickshaws	₹100	₹100	
Birgunj night (hotel, 3 rooms)	₹600	₹900	No real Airbnb supply
Birgunj → Kathmandu	₹500	₹1,700	Day bus vs hired Hiace for 6
Kathmandu taxis, 2 days (2 cabs)	₹800	₹1,000	
Entry tickets at SAARC rates (Durbar Squares, Swayambhu, Boudha)	₹700	₹900	
Kathmandu → Dumre (tourist bus) + jeep to Bandipur	₹600	₹600	
Bandipur → Pokhara bus	₹250	₹250	
Pokhara: boat, Sarangkot sunrise taxi, local	₹600	₹800	
Pokhara → Birgunj bus	₹700	₹1,000	Local vs tourist/AC
Raxaul → Patna bus	₹450	₹600	
Patna night before the train	₹700	₹1,000	Airbnb/hotel near Danapur
12792 Danapur → Secunderabad (12:15)	₹840	₹2,200	SL vs 3A
Airbnb Nepal: Kathmandu 2N, Bandipur 1N, Pokhara 2N (NYE)	₹4,000	₹6,400	Entire 3BR apartments ÷ 6
Food, 10 days (incl. 4 train days)	₹6,000	₹7,000	Dal bhat sets are cheap and filling
Nepali SIM / eSIM, exchange margin	₹300	₹400	
Buffer	₹800	₹1,000	
TOTAL per person	**₹18,810**	**₹28,150**	**Fits ₹25–30k comfortably on SL, and still does in 3A.**

Bookings to do now

- **17005 for 24 Dec today** (weekly train). Then 12792 Danapur → Secunderabad for 2 Jan.
- Airbnb Pokhara 30–31 Dec (NYE festival demand), then Kathmandu.
- Check every adult's passport or voter ID. Photocopies of both, plus 2 photos each.

Plan B

- 17005 waitlisted: Hyderabad → Patna/Danapur by 12791 (daily, Secunderabad ~09:25 → Danapur ~18:15 next day) on 24 Dec, then bus Patna → Raxaul.
- Fog delays the train into Raxaul: sleep in Birgunj and leave for Kathmandu at dawn as planned.
- Want snow-peak views up close: swap Bandipur for Nagarkot (sunrise on the Langtang–Everest range).

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** each (Sikkim/Bhutan permits, J&K checks). **Nepal: passport or voter ID** (Aadhaar is generally not accepted).
- Power bank (cold halves battery life), offline maps, ₹5–8k cash each (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Group med kit: paracetamol, ORS, cold/cough tablets, band-aids, Vaseline, motion-sickness tablets (hill roads). Diamox only on a doctor's advice.
- Thermos for hot water, quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear, a 3-pin multi-plug for the Airbnb (one socket per room is common).
- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K don't work in Kashmir. Carry at least 2 postpaid connections in the group (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Roads and snow change by the hour. Check state police traffic updates and ask your host each evening. Emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- No two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice. Taxis with chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book 30 Dec–1 Jan stays first (NYE rates 2–3×). Prefer flexible cancellation.
- Start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/railhead) by 1 Jan. NYE traffic and snow delay buses 3–8 h.
- Use only registered paragliding operators in Pokhara. Avoid night buses on Nepal's mountain highways.

Sources checked

Reddit and direct page fetches (Airbnb, IRCTC, erail, ConfirmTkt) were blocked from this environment, so everything here comes from web-search results: Airbnb listing snippets, rail timetable aggregators, Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live prices could not be checked; use the checklists above to verify.

— 17005/17006 Hyderabad–Raxaul: ixigo, totaltraininfo, ConfirmTkt, RailMitra, indiantrain (Thu 23:10; Raxaul ~16:50–17:00; 17006 Sun 03:15)
— 12792/12791 Danapur–Secunderabad: totaltraininfo, ixigo, RailMitra, Trainman (12:15 → 21:30 next day, daily)
— Nepal entry documents & Indian currency rules: HappyFares Nepal visa guide 2026, Business Today (Jul 2026), Deccan Chronicle, Niva Bupa
— Birgunj–Kathmandu and Kathmandu–Pokhara buses: 12go, Bookaway, The Himalayan Times, bussewa (2026), In Your Pocket; Bandipur via Dumre: hopnepal, kimkim
— Pokhara Street Festival dates: The Himalayan Times, Ratopati, Kathmandu Post, Republica
— Airbnb listings: airbnb.com Kathmandu/Thamel/Pokhara Lakeside pages via search (Nov 2026)
— International comparison: Bhutan SDF (Consulate General of India Phuentsholing, discoverwithdheeraj, maverickbird); HYD–CMB/BKK/KUL fares: Skyscanner, IndiGo, Air India, AirAsia, Trripah (Nov 2026)